The Cross: The Final Lamb

Mark 14–15; Luke 22–23; Isaiah 53; Hebrews 10

The big idea: Every lamb in the story pointed to the cross. Jesus gave the new covenant in his blood, drank the cup of God's wrath, took the place of the guilty, and cried, It is finished. As our substitute he bore the punishment our sins deserved, so that God is just and the justifier of everyone who has faith in Jesus.

Before you meet: Read

Mark 14:12–50 | Mark 15:1–39 | Luke 23:33–46 | Isaiah 52:13–53:12 | Hebrews 10:11–22

Open (5 minutes)

Has anyone ever taken the blame or paid a price for something you did? How did it feel?

Observe (fill in from the passage)

"This cup that is poured out for you is the new _____ in my blood." *(Luke 22:20)*

"Remove this cup from me. Yet not what I _____, but what you will." *(Mark 14:36)*

"Jesus, _____ me when you come into your kingdom." *(Luke 23:42)*

"My God, my God, why have you _____ me?" *(Mark 15:34)*

"But he was pierced for our _____; he was crushed for our iniquities." *(Isaiah 53:5)*

"For our sake he made him to be _____ who knew no sin, so that in him we might become the righteousness of God." *(2 Corinthians 5:21)*

Discuss

1. Trace the lamb thread from Genesis 22 to the cross. Which link in that chain means the most to you now?
Genesis 22:8; Exodus 12:13; John 1:29

2. What was the cup Jesus asked the Father to remove? Why did he drink it anyway? *Mark 14:32–36; Isaiah 51:17*

3. Barabbas went free while Jesus was condemned. How is that a picture of what Jesus does for sinners?
Mark 15:6–15

4. The thief on the cross was saved with no time to do good works. What does that teach about how anyone is saved? *Luke 23:39–43*

5. Substitution, propitiation, redemption, reconciliation, victory: which picture of the cross do you need most right now? *1 Peter 2:24; 1 John 4:10; Mark 10:45; Romans 5:10; Colossians 2:15*

6. Paul wrote that the Son of God loved me and gave himself for me. What would change if you really believed that? *Galatians 2:20; Romans 5:8*

Apply this week

Read Mark 14–15 in one sitting, then read Isaiah 53. If you have trusted Christ, read Galatians 2:20 aloud with your own name in it; if you have not, read it as an invitation. Bring one hard thing to God and pray, Not what I will, but what you will.

Memory verse

"But he was pierced for our transgressions; he was crushed for our iniquities; upon him was the chastisement that brought us peace, and with his wounds we are healed."

Isaiah 53:5

Pray

Thank Jesus for drinking the cup of wrath, for taking the place of the guilty, and for crying, It is finished. Confess your sin and rest in his finished work. Like the thief, ask him to remember you, and thank him that there is no condemnation for those who are in Christ Jesus.

LEADER NOTES · LESSON 21

The Cross: The Final Lamb

Session plan (about 70 minutes)

5 min	Welcome, opening prayer, and the Open question.
10 min	Read Mark 15:22–39 aloud together. Then read Isaiah 53:4–6.
10 min	Observe: work through the fill-ins together. Use the answer key below.
30 min	Discuss: choose 4 of the 6 questions. Questions 2, 4, and 6 matter most.
5 min	Walk the group through the Isaiah 53 table and the What Jesus Did on the Cross chart in the full lesson.
10 min	Apply and pray. Introduce the memory verse and the reading for Lesson 22 (Mark 16; Luke 24; 1 Corinthians 15:1–28; Acts 1:1–11).

Main points to land

1. Jesus is the Lamb God provided. Every lamb in the story, from Moriah to the Passover to the Day of Atonement, pointed to him (Genesis 22:8; John 1:29; 1 Corinthians 5:7).
2. At the Last Supper, Jesus gave the new covenant in his blood. In the Lord's Supper, believers feed on him by faith (Luke 22:19–20; WSC 96).
3. In Gethsemane and on the cross, Jesus drank the cup of God's wrath as our substitute, bearing the punishment our sins deserved (Mark 14:36; 15:34; 2 Corinthians 5:21).
4. The cross is propitiation: God is both just and the justifier of the one who has faith in Jesus (Romans 3:26; 1 John 4:10).
5. It is finished. Nothing is left to pay, and there is no condemnation for those who are in Christ Jesus (John 19:30; Hebrews 10:12–14; Romans 8:1).

Core doctrine to teach

The Lord's Supper CORE DOCTRINE 21 OF 26

On the night he was betrayed, Jesus took bread and the cup and told his followers to eat and drink in remembrance of him. The Lord's Supper proclaims his death until he comes. In it believers remember Christ, are strengthened in faith, and share in his body together (1 Corinthians 10:16–17). *Luke 22:19–20; 1 Corinthians 10:16–17; 11:23–29*

Answer key (Observe)

1. covenant
2. will
3. remember
4. forsaken
5. transgressions

6. sin

Questions people will ask

Isn't it unjust for God to punish an innocent person for others?
It would be, if Jesus were an unwilling third party. But he is God the Son, who freely laid down his life (John 10:18), the Judge taking the penalty himself out of love (1 John 4:10). God does not ignore sin; he punishes it fully in his Son, so that he is both just and the justifier (Romans 3:26).

Did the Father really abandon the Son?
On the cross Jesus, as our substitute, bore the Father's just wrath and felt the full weight of being forsaken. Yet the Trinity was never torn apart, and Jesus still cried My God (Mark 15:34). He went into that darkness so that we would never be forsaken (WCF 8.4).

Who killed Jesus?
Peter answers both sides: God delivered him up by his definite plan, and lawless men crucified him (Acts 2:23). God planned it, people were guilty of it, and Jesus went willingly (John 10:18). Christians have never blamed one people for it; our sins sent him there.

Can anyone take the Lord's Supper?
The Supper is for those who trust Christ and examine themselves (1 Corinthians 11:28). Churches differ on whether baptism and membership must come first, so if you are not sure, talk with a pastor. If you are not there yet, talk with a pastor. The cross is offered to everyone; the table is where those who have received Christ keep coming back to feed on him by faith.

Closing prayer

Lord Jesus, you are the Lamb God provided. You drank the cup we deserved, took the place of the guilty, and cried, It is finished. Thank you that you loved sinners and gave yourself for them. Help each of us to rest in your finished work, to turn from our sin, and to trust you alone. There is now no condemnation for those who are in you. Amen.